have shed their old antipathies and begun to look at this new Congress anew. In this sense, the Yatra interestingly recaptured the centre. I think this is one of its key achievements. Because of the nature of contemporary politics, there is seldom an opportunity to pursue causes that go far beyond political differences and be driven by our shared values (enshrined in the Constitution). The Yatra upheld the notion that bringing people together does not call for negativing honest differences of opinion—rather, it seeks coexistence in the people's and nation's interest.

In this spirit, '*Nafrat ke bazaar mein mohabbat ki dukaan* (a shop furthering love in a bazaar of hate)' should not be understood as fostering opposing camps among the people. In the Gandhian tradition, mohabbat (love) is about consciously not seeing anyone as the 'other' and, instead, converting them by example and persuasion. The aspiration is to avoid creating permanent walls of separation and, instead, create bridges of understanding. This is premised on the belief that all humans are essentially good, but circumstances and conditioning make them take to hate. Rahul frequently spoke of his tapasya (reflective endeavour) to forgive those who vilified him and his values.

In India, sacrifice and saintliness (not only as a code of conduct, but as an act of seeking the truth) have always been held in high regard. Consequently, Rahul's avowed normative stance had a dramatic impact, even on the few detractors who turned up to shout slogans from a distance to register their presence. Rahul did not ignore or confront them, but waved cheerfully and blew flying kisses. I imagine this had a disarming effect on those detractors; it certainly forced many in India to sit up and take notice of this very different way of tackling hate and toxicity.

This same impact was mirrored in the Kashmir Valley, which gave a warm response to a son of the soul returning home. In Kashmir, mass leaders pull crowds of 5,000 to 10,000. Yet, more than 25,000 people turned up on the first day of the Yatra, and it just kept growing. I think Kashmiris intuitively knew that the Yatra had come to heal their wounds and spread the message of love that the Sufis of Kashmir had traditionally imparted and which seemed lost in the induced pall of violence that had played havoc